FREE SOP DOCUMENT

SOP: using Meta Ads MCP and the Ads CLI safely

Five phases from read-only audit to a human approving spend.

Document control	
Owner	_____
Reviewer	_____
Version and date	_____
Ad account(s) covered	_____

1. Purpose and scope

To let people use an AI assistant (through Meta's Ads MCP server) or the Ads CLI to analyse and prepare work in a Meta ad account without unapproved changes or spend. Scope: Facebook and Instagram ad accounts the business owns. Out of scope: bidding algorithms and time-critical changes.

2. Roles

Role	Responsibility
Account owner	The business that owns the ad account and Business Manager; grants and revokes access.
Operator	Runs the AI assistant or CLI; prepares audits, proposals and paused drafts.
Approver	A different person who approves proposals and activates ads. One person must not do both for new spend.

3. Prerequisites checklist

- ☐ The business, not a freelancer, owns the ad account and Business Manager.
- ☐ Access given is the least the job needs (read for audits; management only for drafting).
- ☐ MCP route: sign-in by OAuth or token as Meta's documentation describes. System user tokens must be Employee role; Meta's docs say Admin-role tokens cannot access the ads MCP server.
- ☐ CLI route: a system user is created in Business Settings and added to the app and each ad account; token saved in a .env file kept out of version control.
- ☐ A practice or low-spend account is used for first runs.
- ☐ Everyone has read Meta's current documentation on the day of setup.
- ☐ Activity log is checked weekly by the Account owner.

> **Golden rule.** The AI proposes, a human decides, and money moves only after a human says so.

4. Procedure: five phases

Phase	What happens	Tools (per Meta docs)	Stop rule
0. Access	Connect MCP or install CLI; confirm setup.	`claude mcp add ... https://mcp.facebook.com/ads`; `meta auth status`	Stop if access is broader than needed.
1. Read-only audit	Last 30 days: what works, what wastes money.	`ads_get_ad_entities`, `ads_insights_performance_trend`, `ads_insights_anomaly_signal`; `meta ads insights get`	Stop if the AI calls any create, update, activate or delete tool.
2. Change check	Who changed what in the last two weeks.	`ads_account_get_activity_logs`	Stop and fix access if unknown users made changes.
3. Proposals	AI lists up to three changes with benefit and risk.	None (words only)	No execution without written approval.
4. Paused drafts	Create approved items as drafts; show command first.	`ads_create_campaign`, `ads_create_ad_set`, `ads_create_ad`; `meta ads campaign create`	Stop if anything is not PAUSED.
5. Activate and log	Approver checks in Ads Manager, activates campaign, ad set, ad in order, logs it.	Human step (`ads_activate_entity` needs confirmation)	Re-run the audit after one week.

5. RTCROS prompts for the two riskiest phases

Phase 1. Role: Senior paid social analyst. **Task:** Audit the last 30 days; say what works, what wastes money, what to check first. **Context:** [business, goal, monthly budget]. **Rules:** Read-only. Do not call any tool that creates, updates, activates or deletes. Use only returned data. Say when a number is missing. List reasons as hypotheses. **Output format:** Three sections plus a table of top five campaigns by spend. **Style:** Plain English.

Phase 4. Role: Assistant preparing drafts for human review. **Task:** Create the approved campaign as a draft. **Context:** [paste approved change, objective, budget, audience]. **Rules:** Create everything paused. Show me the exact call or command and wait for me to type APPROVE. Never call an activate tool or set a status to active. **Output format:** List each object with name, ID, status. **Style:** Concise.

Units check. Meta's CLI tutorial uses `--daily-budget 5000` without stating the unit on the page we read. Confirm in the command reference how budget values are interpreted before entering a real amount.

6. Command cheat sheet (Ads CLI, from Meta's documentation)

Job	Command
Check setup	`meta auth status`
List ad accounts	`meta ads adaccount list`
List campaigns	`meta ads campaign list`
Performance	`meta ads insights get --fields spend,impressions,ctr,cpc`
Campaigns as JSON	`meta --output json ads campaign list`
Activate (human step only)	`meta ads campaign update <CAMPAIGN_ID> --status ACTIVE`

Global options such as `--output` go before the subcommand. Exit codes: 0 success, 1 general error, 2 usage, 3 authentication, 4 API error, 5 not found. Settings resolve: command-line flags, then environment variables, then the .env file.

7. Safety rules

- ☐ Separate read-only and write connections; few people hold the write one.
- ☐ Never put `--force` or `--no-input` delete commands into automated jobs untested. They skip prompts, and deleting a campaign deletes its ad sets and ads.
- ☐ Prefer Meta's official server; treat any third-party server like a vendor with account access.
- ☐ Keep tokens and .env files out of chats, shared folders and version control.
- ☐ A human activates every new ad. No exceptions for "small" budgets.
- ☐ Review the activity log weekly.

8. Sign-off log

Date	Operator	Change made	Approver	Result

Based on Meta for Developers documentation (Ads MCP server and Ads CLI), read 3 November 2026. Not run against a live account for this document; confirm every command against Meta's current pages. Full guide: aiinmarketing.in/blogs/meta-ads-mcp-and-cli-sop